

Node.js & VS Code Installation

Everything from the Day 1 videos in one place: what you installed, why it matters for automation, and hands-on tasks to make sure your setup really works before Day 2.

What is Node.js?

Node.js is a **JavaScript runtime** — it lets you run JavaScript outside the browser, straight from your terminal. Playwright, npm and almost all modern test tooling run on top of it.

- It ships with **npm** (Node Package Manager), which installs libraries like Playwright into your projects.
- Always install the **LTS** (Long-Term Support) version for stability.

```
node -v    // prints the Node version, e.g. v22.11.0
npm -v     // prints the npm version, e.g. 10.9.0
```

Visual Studio Code

VS Code is the editor we use for the whole course. Two habits to build from day one:

- Open the **integrated terminal** with **Ctrl + `** so you can run code without leaving the editor.
- Open a project folder (File > Open Folder, or `code .` from a terminal) instead of opening loose files.

Recommended extensions: **Prettier** (auto-formatting) and, later in the course, **Playwright Test for VS Code**.

Running your first script

```
// hello.js
console.log("Hello from Node.js!");
// in the terminal, from the file's folder:
// node hello.js
```

Quick reference

Command / shortcut	What it does
<code>node -v</code>	Show the installed Node.js version (proves the install worked)
<code>npm -v</code>	Show the installed npm version
<code>node file.js</code>	Run a JavaScript file with Node
<code>code .</code>	Open the current folder in VS Code
<code>Ctrl + `</code>	Open / close the integrated terminal in VS Code

Practice exercises

Do these in VS Code, run them with Node, and bring questions to the next live Q&A.

1. Open a terminal and run `node -v` and `npm -v`. Write both version numbers down.

Hint: If either command is not recognised, Node is not on your PATH — re-run the installer and restart the terminal.

2. Create a folder called `learn-with-palla` and open it in VS Code.
3. Inside it, create `hello.js` that prints "Hello, <your name>!" using `console.log`, then run it with `node hello.js`.
4. Add a second line that prints the result of `7 * 6`.

Hint: `console.log` can print numbers and expressions directly — no quotes needed.

5. Install the Prettier extension, then right-click your file and choose "Format Document".

Bonus challenge — Make a file `today.js` that prints the current date and time using `new Date()`. Run it twice and confirm the time changes.